

Headphones are more cost effective than speakers and a speaker with similar quality to a headphone will be around 10x the price

Power (in RMS) is actually a measure of the electrical power that is transferred from an amplifier to a loudspeaker

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Logitech Z5500

with. In fact, the length of cables bundled with a surround speaker system is important if you plan to place the satellite speakers a fair distance apart.

5.1 speakers systems are now much cheaper than they were couple of years ago. Due to the attrition we spoke about earlier, desktop surround speakers have lost a lot of ground to home-theatre systems and their ilk. Therefore, options are somewhat limited. We were only able to get our hands on four sets.

Features:

The Logitech Z5500 warrants mention first. At first glance, it's obvious that this speaker is a high-end set. It's got a huge woofer unit with a massive 10-inch driver. In fact, this woofer unit looks really mean and is really heavy. The satellites are solidly built and feature two-way drivers. There is also an external decoder unit complete with LCD display and even digital connectivity. In fact, this was the only speaker in test to feature digital connects and that too, both coaxial and optical were provided. The decoder allows a maximum sampling rate of 96 KHz at 24-bits; 192 KHz at 16-bit quality is also supported.

Dolby DTS is supported, which is good for movie buffs. The decoder unit serves as a wired remote and a wireless remote control has also been provided to keep couch potatoes happy. The Creative Inspire T6100 was the next unit we

unpacked. This one has a much smaller woofer unit than the colossal Z5500's unit. The satellites look neat with a slim, tall appearance and a slight characteristic (for Creative) bulge in the middle. The Altec Lansing VS3251 was the third speaker system that we unboxed and once we unpacked it everyone was surprised at how simple it looks. In fact, the satellites look ultra-simple and there is nothing special about them at all. Even the choice of materials used in the construction is drab, even though overall build quality is good. The fourth speaker set in this category was another Logitech offering — the X 540. The satellite units look cool with a net-like material used for the construction of the speaker grilles. The woofer is a smallish unit and the entire speaker set looks built for compactness. The satellites have stands that swivel so that the speakers can be wall hung and while this is a great feature we found that every stand had some play which probably occurred while repeatedly twisting the speaker stands. The Z5500 also has this feature (swivel stands) but the construction is much more robust — no such issues with unnecessary play developing there.

Performance:

When it comes to music, everyone demands quick bass response sans the boom: a liquid and smooth flowing mid-range that is musical, while retaining detail, and a high-end that is revealing without being overly harsh

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and sibilant. When it comes to testing speakers for movies, the rules change somewhat. We actually welcome more bass, more thuds and thumps for it bring the most dramatic movie sequences to life. Imagine an Anakin Skywalker lightsaber battle with tinny sounding lightsabers, cannot can you? Or imagine artillery fire in the *Transformers* without the accompanying rattle of windows. In this regard, the Logitech Z5500 really shines. It's a superb set of speakers for any sort of movie or gaming situation and produces some of the most powerful bass you'll ever hear from a PC speaker system. In fact, low frequency sound comes to life with this speaker system. The satellites are also powerful enough to chime in when required although the bass needs to be adjusted to a lower setting for fear of it drowning out the satellites totally. The mid-range is slightly recessed and this is not the best speaker for music, but other than that, the vocals and guitar sounds quite nice. The highs are also rolled off without the assistance of a dedicated driver for their reproduction. In the music test, we noticed some cabinets ringing with Eric Clapton's *Tears In Heaven* and the recessed mid-range didn't help the textural richness of the guitar strums. *Everybody Hurts* sounds pretty sublime and Andrea Corr's voice is done very well. There was also some slight issues with sound staging in Pink Floyd's *Money* where the highs seemed to be lacking some of the crispness that were expected. It's still the best sounding 5.1-speaker system in this test. The Altec Lansing VS 3251 was the most mediocre of these four speakers in terms of performance; however, it's still not a bad option for those looking either at music or movies, and to be quite honest, none of the 5.1 speakers could be termed as poor or even mediocre — they were all good! The Creative Inspire T6100 and Logitech X 540 are very close to each other in terms of performance, with the slight edge going to the Logitech unit for movies and the Creative offering when it came to accurate sound staging with music.

Winners:

When it comes to choosing a best value winner, the Altec Lansing VS 3251 rears its head as the cheapest 5.1-speaker in test. It also performs well and courtesy of its all-round capabilities, it gets our much coveted Digit Best Buy award. If you're looking for a little more oomph and are willing to shell out Rs 2,000 or so more, look at the Logitech X 540. When it came to our Best Performer, we were at a slight impasse. On one hand, the Logitech Z5500 was the single most impressive all rounder in this test. It did music fairly well while performing, giving us a sterling show when it came to the movie tests. It's built well and also happens to have the most features on board. However, this is not the best speaker for music. In the end though we gave up our nitpicking, especially since the test results all pointed to one entity — the Z5500 now sports the Best Performer trophy on its mantle. ■

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Altec Lansing VS3251